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Hopes rise as top US envoys join Gaza talks

AL SISSI INVITES TRUMP TO EGYPT
FOR A POSSIBLE PEACE DEAL SIGNING

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

Top US negotiators joined high-stakes discussions in Sharm Al Shaikh yesterday aimed at ending the Gaza war, with Egypt and Hamas both voicing “encouraging” signs of progress. Egyptian President Abdul Fattah Al Sissi said he had received “very positive” feedback since the arrival of US President Donald Trump’s envoys — senior adviser Jared Kushner and Middle East envoy Steve Witkoff. “The envoys came with a strong will, a strong message, and a strong mandate from President Trump to end the war in this round of negotiations,” Al Sissi said, calling the early signs “very encouraging.” He invited Trump to travel to Egypt for a possible signing ceremony should a deal be reached.

Trump upbeat

Trump’s 20-point Gaza peace plan, now the basis of the talks, calls for a ceasefire, the release of all hostages, Hamas’s disarmament, and a phased Israeli withdrawal from the enclave. At the White House on Tuesday, Trump told reporters, “There’s a possibility we could have peace in the Middle East.” Senior Hamas official Taher Al Nunu told AFP from Sharm

Al Shaikh that “mediators are making great efforts to remove obstacles to the ceasefire’s implementation, and a spirit of optimism prevails.” He said Hamas had submitted a list of Palestinian prisoners it wants released from Israeli jails in the first phase of the truce, “in accordance with the agreed-upon criteria and numbers.” In return, Hamas is expected to release 47 hostages, both alive and dead, seized during its October 7, 2023 attack on Israel that triggered the war.

Key point of contention

The talks — attended by Qatari Prime Minister Shaikh Mohammad Bin Abdulrahman Al Thani and Turkish intelligence chief Ibrahim Kalin — are taking place under the shadow of that attack’s second anniversary. A key point of contention remains the hostage-prisoner exchange and guarantees that the war will not resume after a deal. Egyptian media said Hamas is pushing for the release of Marwan Barghouti, the jailed Fatah leader often called the “Palestinian Mandela”. Barghouti has been in prison since 2002. Hamas negotiator Khalil Al Hayya said the group is seeking “guarantees from President Trump and the sponsor countries that the war will end once and for all.”

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WAM

PRESIDENT, EMIR OF KUWAIT DISCUSS REGIONAL DEVELOPMENTS

President His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan met yesterday with Shaikh Meshal Al Ahmad Al Jaber Al Sabah, Emir of Kuwait, to discuss the deep-rooted fraternal ties and ways to enhance cooperation, particularly in the development and economic sectors, to advance their mutual interests and support the prosperity of both peoples.

Gold peaks over 40 times this year

Bullion up 1.7% to
new record of \$4,048
an ounce yesterday

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Gold isn’t done surprising investors yet. Prices set a record of \$3,825 an ounce last month, then shot past \$4,000 for a second time yesterday — hitting over 40 all-time highs this year alone. Bullion rose 1.7 per cent to a new record \$4,048 an ounce. UAE gold prices pushed closer to the symbolic Dh500 per gram mark for 24-karat

gold, while 22K gold, the favourite among UAE shoppers, hit Dh450.50 yesterday. “Gold has done it. Gold has reached the long-awaited \$4,000 per ounce mark, a level that carries psychological and symbolic significance,” said Ahmad Assiri, GCC-focused market strategist at Dubai-based Pepperstone.

Pivotal chapter

“This moment represents a powerful and sustained rally that began with a breakout from a lengthy consolidation phase in early September, evolving into a pivotal chapter for the market and gold. Since that breakout, gold has risen

by 16 per cent, while attempts at a pullback has remained shallow and shortlived.” The World Gold Council’s latest Gold Market Commentary suggests this rally isn’t slowing anytime soon — and UAE shoppers hoping for a price dip may have to wait. Three forces are driving the surge: Record inflows into gold-backed ETFs, a weaker US dollar, and growing global uncertainty. The report warns that October could be rough if a market correction pushes more investors into gold. Despite short-term dips, analysts say gold remains a reliable hedge as central banks and funds keep buying. SEE ALSO P7

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